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The Odyssey

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BOOK I

The Man of Many Turnings

Tell me, O Muse, of the man of many turnings, who, having overthrown Troy's sacred citadel, wandered far, and saw the cities of many men, and learned their minds, and suffered on the sea many deep sorrows, striving to save his life and bring his companions home. Still he could not save them, though he longed to do so: their own blind folly brought them to destruction, for they devoured the cattle of the Sun, and he took from them the day of their returning. Begin wherever you will, goddess born of Zeus; give us this story also. All the others now, who had escaped the steep destruction of the war, were home, beyond the battle and the sea. He alone, still longing for his wife and for the day of return, was held in hollow caves by the lady nymph, Calypso, shining among the deathless ones, who longed to have him for her husband. But when the circling years had brought the hour the gods had spun for him to reach his home, to Ithaca, not even there was he released from toil among his friends; yet all the gods took pity on him, save Poseidon; he, unrelenting, nursed his wrath against godlike Odysseus, till he touched the land he loved. But Poseidon had gone to the distant Ethiopians, the farthest of men, divided at the world's two ends, where the Sun goes down and rises, to share a hecatomb of bulls and rams. There he sat at the feast; the other gods were gathered in the halls of Zeus on high Olympus. The father of gods and men began to speak, remembering Aegisthus, whom famed Orestes killed. "Look how mortals blame the gods," he said, "and say their evils come from us. Yet they themselves, by folly, make sorrow beyond what fate has given them. So Aegisthus, against fate, took Agamemnon's wife and murdered him when he came home from Troy. He knew the god's warning, for Hermes had told him: do not kill the king, do not pursue his wife; the son of Atreus will be avenged by Orestes,

when he comes to manhood and longs for his country.

But Aegisthus would not listen. Now he has paid for all of it at once."

Then the grey-eyed Athena answered him:

"Father Zeus, son of Cronus, highest of rulers, that man deserved the death that came upon him. Would that every man who acts as he did might perish!

But my heart is troubled for the wise Odysseus, who has so long been kept from his friends and home,

on an island in the sea, where the nymph, the daughter

of great Atlas, who knows the sea's every depth, holds him in her hollow caves.

Poseidon still keeps the anger that began with the Cyclops, whom Odysseus blinded, the most powerful of his sons.

Zeus, cloud-gatherer, answered: "If your heart is set, go now and ask the swift one, Hermes, to tell the nymph

that we have decided: let the steadfast man go home.

Poseidon will not kill him, but drive him far from his own fatherland."

Athena said: "Father, if this is truly your will, send Hermes at once. I will go to Ithaca myself, and strengthen the heart of his son, so that he calls the long-haired Achaeans to assembly and speaks against the suitors who consume his house and wealth.

Then I will lead him to Pylos and to Lacedaemon, to seek news of his father, if perhaps that report may lift him into manhood and give him a name."

She fastened beneath her feet the golden sandals, deathless, winged, that carry her above the water and over the measureless earth, swift as the wind. She took the spear, great, heavy, edged with bronze,

with which the daughter of a mighty father breaks the ranks of heroes when her anger is awakened. Down from Olympus she came. She stood in Ithaca, before the doors of Odysseus, at the outer court, holding the shape of Mentès, lord of the Taphians. There she found the proud suitors. They were amusing themselves with stones and dice before the doors, while the servants cut the meat and mixed the wine.

Telemachus saw her first. He sat among the feasters,

grieving within his heart, imagining his noble
 father,
 if he might come and scatter these men from the
 house,
 recover his honor, and rule his own possessions.
 He went directly to the gate, since it shamed him
 to let a stranger stand waiting. He took her hand,
 received her spear, and spoke with winged words:
 "Stranger, welcome. You shall be received among
 us.
 First take food, and afterward tell us what you
 seek."
 He led her through the house, and set the spear
 against a shining pillar in the spear-stand,
 where many other weapons rested, long ago
 carried by Odysseus, but now covered from sight.
 He brought her to a chair, carved and polished,
 beautiful, high-backed, with a woven cloth laid
 over it;
 for himself he drew a smaller seat beside her,
 apart from the suitors, lest the stranger be
 disturbed
 by their loud shouting and their insolent feast,
 and lest, while eating, he should question him
 about his father, whom he had so long desired.
 A maid brought water in a golden pitcher,
 and poured it over their hands into a silver basin.
 Then an honored housekeeper set a polished table
 before them. She brought bread, and many dishes,
 giving freely from the stores she kept within.
 The carver lifted platters of many kinds of meat,
 and set beside them cups of gold. The herald
 came often, pouring wine among the guests.
 The suitors entered then, the proud young men,
 and sat in order on the benches and the chairs.
 The heralds poured water over their hands;
 the serving women filled baskets with bread;
 and boys crowned the mixing bowls with wine.
 They reached for the food placed before them.
 When they had eaten and had driven hunger away,
 the singer Phemius took his resonant lyre;
 the suitors had compelled him to sing among them.
 He struck the opening chord, and began a song
 of the hard return of the Achaeans from Troy,
 the homeward passage the gods had made bitter.
 From her upper room Penelope heard the inspired
 singer,
 and came down the polished stairs—not alone:
 two attendants followed close behind her.
 When she had drawn near the suitors, she stood
 beside the pillar supporting the roof, and held
 a shining veil before her face. Then she spoke
 through tears to the divine singer:

"Phemius, many other songs you know to delight
 the hearts of mortal men, the deeds of gods and
 heroes,
 which singers make famous. Choose one of these,
 and let them drink in silence. But do not sing
 this sorrowful return. It cuts my heart within me,
 for I remember the man I cannot cease to mourn.
 His fame was wide through Hellas and midmost
 Argos."
 Then wise Telemachus answered her:
 "Mother, why deny the singer that he wishes?
 The singers are not to blame for what has come;
 Zeus gives to each man as he himself determines.
 He sings the hardest fate of the Danaans.
 Let him go on, since men most praise the newest
 song.
 Your heart and spirit should endure it, too:
 Odysseus was not the only man to lose the day
 of his return from Troy. Many others perished.
 Go to your chamber now, and care for what
 belongs to you:
 the loom, the distaff, and the work you give your
 women.
 Speech is the concern of every man, but mine above
 all;
 in this house I hold the power."
 She was astonished, and returned into the house,
 keeping her son's wise saying in her heart.
 When she had reached her upper room with her
 attendants,
 she wept for Odysseus, her dear husband, until
 bright-eyed Athena
 cast sweet sleep upon her eyelids.
 The suitors stirred the shadowed hall with noise,
 each one desiring to lie beside her.
 Telemachus then addressed them. His voice was
 steady:
 "You suitors of my mother, who carry yourselves
 with pride,
 let us feast in quiet, and take pleasure in listening.
 It is a beautiful thing to hear a singer such as this.
 At dawn let us go to the assembly, every man,
 so I may speak openly and order you away.
 Leave this house. Hold your own banquets
 elsewhere,
 and consume your own possessions, taking turns by
 house.
 But if you think it better and more profitable
 to consume one man's goods without payment,
 then waste them. I will cry to the everlasting gods,
 and may Zeus make the debt come due."
 They all fell silent, and looked at him in wonder.
 Antinous, son of Eupheithes, answered him:

"Telemachus, surely the gods themselves have taught you to speak so boldly, and to make your words a law. May the son of Cronus never grant you kingship in sea-girt Ithaca, though it is your inheritance." Telemachus answered him: "Antinous, if the god wills it, I would accept that gift. Kingship is no shame. But if there is another better man in Ithaca, let him rule; I ask no more than my father's house and the people who were once his to command." Eurymachus, son of Polybus, replied: "The gods alone know who will rule in Ithaca. But your possessions remain your own; no one will take them, while the island stands and the blood in you remains. Tell us, stranger, from what country have you come? What city is yours? What family claims you? You have not arrived on foot; you must have crossed the sea. Did you come as a trader, or as one who roams the waves, like pirates who risk their lives upon the deep, and bring danger to other men?" Telemachus answered: "Stranger, since you ask me plainly, I will tell you. Mentos is my name; I am the son of wise Anchialus, and I rule the oar-loving Taphians. I have come here in my ship and with my companions, crossing the dark sea toward men who speak another tongue. I carry bright iron to Temesa, and my companions carry bronze. I have moored my ship beyond the city, at Reithron's harbor, beneath the wooded hill. We claim an ancient friendship, inherited from our fathers, as old Laertes will confirm. Go ask him, they say, though he no longer enters the town, but stays in the country, grieving, with one old woman who prepares his meals and washes the dirt from his body when age and weariness have taken him." Telemachus answered him, speaking quietly: "I will not trouble the old man. He has suffered much.

My father left no brother or son behind to take his place. He is gone, and no one knows where the earth has hidden him. He may be alive upon the mainland, or on the sea, or dead beneath it. My mother's family and the island's people press me, and these men consume my house." Athena, in the likeness of Mentos, answered him: "It is not fitting for you to remain a child forever. You have heard what kind of man your father was, and how he returned from Troy with honor. Think how Orestes won renown among all men when he avenged his father and killed Aegisthus, the treacherous man who murdered Agamemnon. You too, my friend, must show your strength and courage, so those who come after you will praise your name. As for me, I will return to my ship and my companions. Tomorrow call the people to assembly and speak before them all. Order the suitors to leave. Then go to Pylos and Sparta, and ask about your father, whether any mortal has seen him, or whether report from Zeus has reached the cities. If you hear that he lives and is coming home, endure your grief for one more year, though it cuts you. But if you learn that he is dead and gone, return to your homeland, build a mound, and honor him with all the funeral rites that the dead are owed. Then give your mother to another husband, if she wishes, and devise a death for those men who consume your wealth. You are no longer a child. Have you not heard how Orestes became famous throughout the world? Go now, and let your strength be seen. Your father and your uncle will have something to say about your name, if you are truly their son." Telemachus answered: "All this, stranger, you have spoken with kindness, as a father speaks to his son. I will not forget it. Stay, though you are eager to leave, and bathe; accept a gift, and return to your ship with joy, carrying a precious thing from me, such as hosts give to a guest whom they honor." Athena, with flashing eyes, answered him:

"Do not hold me here, since I am already eager to go.
 Give the gift when I return, and I will take it home.
 Choose something beautiful. You will receive as much in return."
 So she vanished like a bird, and was gone.
 Telemachus knew then, in his heart, that a god had spoken.
 He went among the suitors, no longer walking with lowered eyes.
 The renowned singer still sang, while all listened silently.
 Telemachus addressed them, and his voice carried:
 "You suitors of my mother, who bear yourselves with pride,
 let us feast in silence, and take pleasure in the song.
 At dawn we will go to the assembly, every man,
 so I may tell you plainly to leave this house.
 Hold your own feasts elsewhere, and consume your own possessions,
 going from house to house by turns. But if you decide
 that it is more profitable to consume one man's wealth
 without paying, then waste it. I will cry to the gods,
 and may Zeus make the debt come due."
 They fell silent and looked at him in wonder.
 Antinous, son of Eupieithes, spoke among them:
 "The gods themselves must have taught you to speak so boldly,
 and made your words stand like a king's. May Zeus never grant you
 the kingship in sea-girt Ithaca, though it belongs by birth to you."
 Telemachus answered: "Antinous, if the god should give it,
 I would accept the gift. Kingship is no shame.
 But if another man is better, let him rule the island.
 I ask only to be lord of my own house and possessions,
 the house that Odysseus won, and which no one may consume."
 Eurymachus, son of wise Polybus, replied:
 "The gods alone know who will rule in Ithaca.
 But tell us, stranger, from what country you come?
 What city claims you? Who are your parents?
 You have not come on foot. Surely you crossed the sea.
 Are you a trader, or a wanderer like the pirates
 who risk their lives and bring danger to other men?"
 Telemachus answered: "Since you ask me plainly, I will tell you.

Mentes is my name, son of wise Anchialus, and I rule the Taphians,
 who love the oar. I have come with my ship and companions,
 crossing the dark sea toward men of another tongue.
 I carry bright iron to Temesa, and my companions carry bronze.
 My ship lies beyond the city, at Reithron's harbor,
 beneath the wooded hill. Our fathers were friends,
 as old Laertes will tell you, though grief keeps him in the country.
 But now our guest has departed, and night has come upon us.
 I must prepare the ship and call the people to assembly."
 The suitors rose and went to their houses.
 Telemachus followed the torch held by the faithful old nurse Eurynome,
 who had carried him in her arms when he was newly born.
 She opened the door, and he lay down, turning over in his mind
 the journey Athena had set before him.
 Throughout the night he could not sleep.